

connection. You can even restrict user access to the connection. Red Hat also has a good GUI tool, but the rest only had command-based configuration.

Update to date

All the distributions provide an auto update facility, and make the entire process effortless—SuSE gets a bonus point for providing the update package list with a flag, indicating whether a patch is critical or optional. ELX failed to auto-update despite continuous attempts, possibly because of a problem with the server.

Summary

Mandrake really irritated us while testing; time and again it requested the original CD to install something, it stalled; it even failed to complete installation tasks. Though Xandros, Lycoris and ELX provided all the applications a typical desktop user would need, Red Hat and SuSE offered even more. RHEL would have won the laurels, if only it could handle networking and printing better, but we decided that SuSE was definitely the best, despite being more expensive.

Pricing factor

The Linux distributions tested here can be bought by spending between Rs 500 and Rs 5,000. ELX



BizDesktop costs just Rs 500, and is not a bad choice at all for those interested in getting a feel for Linux. Lycoris Desktop/LX costs Rs 1,800, Xandros costs Rs 2,250, RHEL WS costs Rs 3,250 and SuSE costs the most at Rs 4,850.

Wait! This doesn't mean that SuSE is the most expensive! It actually works out cheaper in the long run. It costs more initially, but you don't have to pay any renewal fees, and get three years of patches free. Red Hat, which has a five-year product cycle, but not from the day you buy it, but from the date of the

product launch. To keep updated, you have to pay an annual charge of 40 per cent of the initial price, which works out to Rs 1,300 for RHEL every year. You get Red Hat updates only if you subscribe, but as a subscriber, you can also download a newer OS versions for free.

SuSE and Red Hat both offer e-mail/web-based support and helplines, that is free for a short while and then costs more. SuSE has regional offices in the four Indian metros and Bangalore, where their support engineers also provide onsite support but this costs extra, of course!

Red Hat too has offices all over India, and offers support in the Metros, Pune and Bangalore. Red Hat onsite support also costs extra.

LIVE CDs What's a LIVE CD?

It's like walking into a bike showroom and taking that Harley Davidson for a spin. You're not risking financial ruin (read: data loss); if you don't like it, you just return the keys and go back to driving your Ducati 999 (read: whatever OS you currently run).

You don't have to partition, install, or risk corrupting the current OS's boot system, nothing! You get stuck somewhere, you decide that you don't like Linux, all you have to do is eject the CD and reboot your PC to get back to your OS of choice. Also, think of it as walking around with the power of Linux in your bag. If a PC has a CD-ROM drive, you can use your favourite LIVE CD distribution on it.

It's not all rosy though: you still have to configure all your devices—network card, modem, VGA driver, etc.—every time the computer boots. Also, the simplest solution to saving data is to use a floppy. You can save to the hard drive, but you can't carry your hard drive around with you, which defeats the whole point of LIVE CDs. Ideally, upload the data to the Internet.

Who and how

We tested three LIVE CD installs—one each from SuSE, Mandrake and Knoppix. Here too, we tested for application support, networking and printing needs of a SoHo business. The applications are a replica of the full system, so they work the same way as we have already seen for the regular distributions.

The SuSE 9.1 Pro LIVE CD was a replica of actual SuSE 9.1 Pro, so all operations such as net-

What Can I Use a LIVE CD For?

Here are a few operations or tasks you might want to use a LIVE CD for:

- ▣ Helping you burn a CD or DVD, if your system has the necessary writer
- ▣ Internet surfing, though you need to configure the modem or LAN card for the same
- ▣ Creating a document in the popular OpenOffice application and printing it
- ▣ Maybe just transferring files over a LAN network
- ▣ For a programmer it is like carrying your development center along with you in your bag
- ▣ Quick scanning and printing work
- ▣ Listening to music or watching movies

working, printing, etc., were similar. SuSE did not auto-mount the Linux or Windows partitions on the hard drive, but Knoppix did. Knoppix also provides a rich set of tools for programmers and developers, and has more applications packed into the CD than either SuSE or Mandrake. Knoppix also includes the Wine emulator, so you can run some of your favourite Windows programs from within Linux.

MandrakeMove requests some user details during boot-up. It also refuses to acknowledge the existence of one-sixth of the

Products Tested

- ▣ Suse 9.1 Pro (www.suse.com)
- ▣ Knoppix 3.4 (www.knoppix.org)
- ▣ MandrakeMove 9.2 (www.mandrakelinux.com)

world's population—when creating a dial-up connection, you have to select a country code, but India doesn't figure on that list! Hence, you will have to go through a lot of trouble configuring it manually—not recommended for beginners. ■

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